

IB English A: Language & Literature SL

Literary Analysis Practice Activities

Lexical resources

Progression: Identification → Explanation → Analysis → Exam Application

How to Use This Resource

The activities are designed to move a student from recognizing authorial choices to explaining their effects and significance in an IB-style analytical response. Repeatedly use the core chain:

Authorial choice → Evidence → Effect → Interpretation → Wider significance

1. Diction

Activity: "Why this word?"

- The man walked into the room.
- Replace walked with: marched, wandered, crept, stumbled, stormed, drifted.
- Ask: What changes? What does each word suggest? Which creates the strongest response? Why might the writer choose one word rather than another?
- IB extension: Identify three significant word choices in a short extract and explain why each matters.

2. Imagery

Activity: Image Detective

- Use a short descriptive passage such as: "The street lay beneath a blanket of grey rain. Neon signs trembled in the puddles, while the wind dragged scraps of newspaper along the pavement."
- Identify visual, auditory and tactile imagery and any personification.
- Ask: What atmosphere is created? How does the imagery position the reader?

3. Metaphor and Simile

Activity: Literal → Figurative → Analytical

- Start with: "She was nervous." Transform it into a simile and a metaphor.
- Ask: What is being compared? Why this comparison? What qualities does it suggest? How does it affect our understanding of the character?
- Challenge: Rank five metaphors from most to least powerful and defend the choices.

4. Symbolism

Activity: Object → Meaning

- Use an object such as a locked door.
- Generate possible meanings: isolation, secrecy, exclusion, fear, lack of freedom, denied opportunity.
- Analyse a passage where the object appears repeatedly. Ask whether its meaning develops across the text.

5. Repetition

Activity: Spot the Pattern

- Example: "I waited for him in the morning. I waited for him at noon. I waited for him when the sun disappeared."
- Identify what is repeated and explain why.
- Ask whether the meaning changes each time. Consider emphasis, emotion, rhythm and obsession.

6. Contrast

Activity: Opposites

- Give pairs such as light/darkness, rich/poor, youth/age, freedom/imprisonment, silence/noise.
- Predict themes each contrast could develop.
- Then analyse an extract using: "The contrast between ___ and ___ highlights ___, suggesting that ___."

7. Tone

Activity: Tone Continuum

- Use: "Well, you finally decided to come."
- Interpret it as sincere, annoyed, sarcastic, relieved, disappointed or amused.
- Ask which words and punctuation make each interpretation possible.
- Stress that tone should be supported by textual choices rather than guessed from the writer's feelings.

8. Irony

Activity: What We Know vs What the Character Knows

- Scenario: A character proudly tells everyone the house is completely safe, while the reader has already been shown that someone is hiding upstairs.
- Separate character knowledge from reader knowledge.
- Identify the effect: suspense, humour or tension. Then introduce verbal, situational and dramatic irony.

9. Characterisation

Activity: Build the Character

- Give an extract containing actions, dialogue, thoughts, appearance and other characters' reactions.
- Complete: "The character appears ___ because ___."
- Upgrade to: "The writer characterises X as ___ through ___. This suggests ___."
- Final question: How does characterisation contribute to the text's central theme?

10. Narrative Perspective

Activity: Same Event, Different Narrator

- Event: A student discovers that her best friend has lied to her.
- Rewrite/describe the event through first person, third-person limited, omniscient and unreliable narration.
- Ask: Which gives greatest access to emotion? Which creates uncertainty? What information is controlled or withheld?

11. Structure

Activity: Rearrange the Story

- Give five events and first arrange them chronologically.
- Then rearrange them to include a flashback or delayed revelation.
- Ask why a writer might avoid chronological order.
- Introduce flashback, foreshadowing, delayed information, repetition and cyclical structure.

12. Setting

Activity: Change the Setting

- Use the same argument between two characters.
- Place it in a crowded restaurant, empty classroom, cemetery, luxury hotel and prison cell.
- Ask how setting changes emotional impact and how setting can reflect psychological state.

13. Dialogue

Activity: What Isn't Being Said?

- Example: "You're home early." / "Yes." / "Everything okay?" / "Fine."
- Ask for literal meaning, implied meaning and what the dialogue reveals.
- Discuss subtext: what the characters avoid saying can be as important as what they say.

14. Shifts in Tone

Activity: Tone Graph

- Track a passage moving from calm → hopeful → anxious → angry → despairing.
- Mark where each shift occurs and identify the textual trigger.
- Ask: Why does the writer shift tone at this particular point?

15. Enjambment

Activity: Stop or Continue?

- Use: "I walked into the night / carrying everything / I could not leave behind."
- Identify where the line ends but the sentence continues.
- Compare with heavily end-stopped lines and discuss pace, flow, thought and emotion.

16. Caesura

Activity: The Interrupted Thought

- Compare: "I wanted to leave but I stayed." and "I wanted to leave — but I stayed."
- Identify the pause and discuss interruption, hesitation, conflict and emphasis.
- Ask why the poet wants the reader to pause.

17. Rhyme

Activity: Break the Pattern

- Give a poem with a regular rhyme scheme such as ABAB.
- Disrupt the pattern in the final stanza.
- Ask why a poet might break an established pattern and what the deviation contributes to meaning or tone.

18. Rhythm

Activity: Read It Aloud

- Compare: "The wind rushed wildly through the trees." with "The wind / moved slowly / through the silent trees."
- Read both aloud.
- Analyse pace, stress, pauses, rhythm and emotional effect.

19. Mixed-Technique IB Practice

Give the student a 200–300 word literary passage. Ask them to identify five significant authorial choices, using each technique no more than once. Possible choices include diction, imagery, metaphor, repetition, contrast, characterisation, dialogue, tone, setting and narrative perspective.

Then ask the student to select the three most important choices and justify why they are significant.

Authorial choice	Evidence	Immediate effect	Deeper meaning
Diction	" ... "	Creates...	Suggests...
Imagery	" ... "	Makes the reader...	Reinforces...
Contrast	" ... "	Highlights...	Develops the theme of...

20. Zoom In → Zoom Out

Use the quotation: "The door remained closed."

- Zoom in: What does "remained" suggest?
- Zoom in: What does "closed" suggest?
- Zoom out: What might the door symbolise?
- Wider text: Does the door appear elsewhere? Does its meaning develop?
- Authorial purpose: Why might the writer choose this image?
- Theme: What larger idea does this contribute to?

21. Final Exam-Style Activity

1. 3 minutes — Annotate the unseen extract for diction, imagery, figurative language, repetition, contrast, tone, characterisation, structure and perspective.
2. 5 minutes — Write a thesis answering: "How does the writer use literary and structural choices to present _____?"
3. Planning — Select three main authorial choices.
4. Paragraph — Point → Evidence → Technique → Effect → Interpretation → Wider significance.
5. Upgrade — Highlight evidence, technique, effect, interpretation and connection to wider meaning in different colours.

Recommended Teaching Sequence

Stage	Focus
Stage 1 – Language	Diction; Imagery; Simile/metaphor; Repetition; Contrast
Stage 2 – Interpretation	Symbolism; Tone; Irony; Characterisation; Dialogue
Stage 3 – Narrative/Structure	Narrative perspective; Setting; Structure; Shifts in tone
Stage 4 – Poetry	Enjambment; Caesura; Rhyme; Rhythm
Stage 5 – IB Integration	Authorial choices; Effect + interpretation; Patterns and connections; Thesis development; Analytical paragraphs; Timed unseen-text practice

Core IB Upgrade

Train the student to move from identification to interpretation. Instead of writing “The writer uses a metaphor,” aim for analysis such as: “The writer’s extended metaphor of confinement presents the character’s emotional state as increasingly restrictive, while recurring imagery of enclosed spaces reinforces the idea that her isolation is psychological rather than merely physical.”